

[1]

On S. Kierkegaard's "Mental State."

By Prof. R. Nielsen.

. . . . Among the strangest things we have witnessed in our day was not so much this, that a man about whose mental state in the last period of his life one cannot have any sure judgment sought a Herostratic fame by hurling insults and accusations against a man's character . . . , but even more wondrous was. . . .
Nyt Theologisk Tidsskrift, edited by Dr. C. E. Scharling and Dr. C. T. Engelstoft,
8th volume, 1st number, 1857, pp. 203 and 204.

In order to be able to have "any sure judgment" about S. Kierkegaard's "mental state," whether in the first or the last period of his life, it is an indispensable condition that one should at least with some reflection consider what it is, then, taken as a whole, that "this man" really wanted, what powers he unfolded, what means he employed, what weapons he used.

"In torments such as a human being has seldom experienced, in exertions of spirit that in the course of 8 days would probably rob another of his reason, I am then, to be sure, also [in possession of a] power, undeniably a consciousness seductive for a poor human being, if the torment and the exertion were not to such a degree the preponderant thing that often enough my wish is death, my longing the grave, my [2] desire that my wish and my longing might soon be fulfilled."

He who thus himself announces his coming forward must, if he is otherwise in his right mind, surely have a burden on his conscience; must, if he really knows what he is saying, have something to say in earnest. What, then, does he want? "Honesty!"

And what is it, then, that he has to say?

"This must be said, so let it then be said: Whoever you are, whatever your life may otherwise be, my friend—by ceasing (if you do otherwise take part in it) to take part in

the public worship of God as it now is (with the claim of being the Christianity of the New Testament) you have continually one, and a great, guilt the less: you do not take part in making a fool of God by calling the Christianity of the New Testament what is not the Christianity of the New Testament."

These are strong words, a judgment that awakens horror. If he who dares to speak thus, and to judge thus, now also really one who has the right, is not society then threatened with a crisis of spirit that in its consequences could become worrying for the state, dangerous for the spiritual peace of the people?

"Herewith—yes, O God, let now be done what Your will is, infinite love!—herewith I have spoken."

This is, to be sure, religious; but is it not, perhaps, once again all too religious?

"Perhaps one person is to hear it in such a way that he does what I say, another in such a way that he takes it as well-pleasing to God, thinks to render God a service of worship by joining in raising an outcry against me: neither of these concerns me; what concerns me is only that it shall be said."

In all this there is a resignation, a resoluteness, a pathos, which undeniably points to a quite peculiar "mental state"; but which? One listens, and asks with anxiety: [3] which? If now, at so critical a moment, the most clear-sighted of the age succeed in seeing through the "mental state" of the man who has come forward, and in convincing themselves that it is by no means one who has the right that they have before them, but a feeble-minded Herostratus, a poor genius who in his overexcitement has gone so far that he has gone out of his mind; then the contemporary age grasps at once that the man is mad, and it is a great comfort to the age "that the man is mad." For, it goes without saying, when the man is mad, then the tension is ended, the crisis over, and "honesty" falls away of itself.

The clear-sighted, who speculate in the advantage of spreading and maintaining the suspicion against K.'s "mental state," so beneficial to the peace of souls, are then naturally also clear with themselves about how this suspicion can find its confirmation from more than one point of view.

From the one side one can concede the truth of everything K. says about the difference between the Christianity of the New Testament and the Christianity of the present day; one can admire the acumen, clarity, consistency and certainty with which he knows how to make the dissimilarity evident, and still find his "mental state" lamentable. His derangement of mind then consists by no means in this, that he does not see what Christianity originally is, but in this, that in dead earnest he wants to

force upon us "the Christianity of the New Testament," wants to screw the age back to that historically superseded standpoint; "so, still that first unconditional faith in the God-man's miracles, still that first ascetic hatred of the world, that dark view of life: the man is surely mad!"

From the other side, on the contrary, one begins with the concession that the Christianity of the New Testament is the only Christianity valid for all times. K.'s error, then, is not that even in our day he demands that the Gospel be acknowledged; but the delusion is that he does not rightly know the Gospel, since he does not see [4] that it is precisely the Christianity of the New Testament that at present finds its most essential expression, its best conditions and most necessary guarantees in the established order. "Unhappy feeble-mindedness, that he could not after all see that it is only something external that has changed here, not the internal; not see that congregational life is still marked by the same brotherly love as in the New Testament; was not granted the grace to see that the servants of the Word, if it came to that, are at once willing to forsake all for Christ's sake, and thus still, save for a few small changes, resemble the disciples in the New Testament; the poor blinded man!"

The circumstance that one can thus by two different ways arrive at the same result concerning K.'s "mental state" one must not, however, be hasty to interpret as if we had here two proofs that fused together into mutual reinforcement. The standpoints indicated are indeed so contradictory to each other that what is adduced from the one side as proof of veracity must be adduced from the other side as a sign of insanity, an inner contradiction that is not exactly fitted to make the judgment secure.

No, in order to have a sure judgment about K.'s "mental state" in the last period of his life, it is necessary that one first form a sure judgment about his "authorship" in the first period. This judgment has in self-complacent superficiality hitherto kept itself so vague, and herein lies the reason why the misunderstanding at the last had to grow to such a height.

To be sure, K. aroused attention at his first appearance, but what was so highly peculiar in his style and manner of writing at once brought it about that he had to repel some to the same degree as he attracted others. At another time, more favorable to deeper-going criticism, this might perhaps have had the beneficial consequence [5] that his view had at once been so strongly lit up from the opposite standpoints that the general consciousness could have followed from the start; now, on the other hand, the interpretation was on the whole left to individual discretion, criticism went about in negligee: the various opinions held good according to taste and fancy.

Thus, to keep here to the religious, some thought that K. really lacked earnestness, while others found in him the strictest earnestness. Among these last stood even Bishop Mynster himself. Already the first "upbuilding discourses" made so earnest an impression on the old Bishop that he, while pronouncing his recognition with weight, even feels moved to give a psychological contribution to a closer understanding of the young man's strange earnestness.

"There is for me," says Bishop Mynster (Kirkelig Polemik. Intelligensblade, ed. J. L. Heiberg. Jan. 1844.) "something touching in Magister Kierkegaard's always dedicating his upbuilding discourses to the memory of his late father. For I too knew this worthy man; he was a plain and simple citizen, went unpretentiously his quiet way through life, had never gone through any 'philosophical bath' whatever. How does it happen, then, that the son, in his rich cultivation, as often as he wishes to write down upbuilding discourses, always turns his thought to that man who long ago entered into rest? Whoever has read the lovely discourse—or let us just call it a sermon—'The Lord gave, the Lord took, blessed be the name of the Lord,' will understand it. The son has, like me, seen the old father at bitter losses, he has seen him fold his hands, bow his venerable head, he has heard his lips utter that word, but at the same time seen his whole being utter it in such a way that he felt what he so beautifully develops about Job, that 'he too is a teacher of mankind who had no teaching to hand over to others, but left the race himself as a pattern, his life as guidance for every human being' who saw it; he has felt that the old man had in his pious word overcome the world. And what the son there in the house of mourning saw in his old father, that he wrote down in a sermon that will speak to, refresh every feeling heart." . . . [6]

If the general judgment about K.'s "religious earnestness" was already somewhat uncertain, the scientific judgment about his religious development of concepts became even entirely confused; he called faith a paradox, after all, and made use of "the indirect form of communication": he repelled the speculative thinkers, he repelled the theologians.

That the rejection of the indirect form was nevertheless still as little unanimous as offense at "the paradox" was general can be seen expressly, among other things, from the way in which Bishop Mynster in the above-mentioned article also speaks of "Fear and Trembling." "I have also," says the Bishop, "read the remarkable writing 'Fear and Trembling,' and whatever I may have missed in it, certainly not a deep religious ground, not a mind that is equal to facing life's highest problems; it has vividly

reminded me of the famous passage in Jacobi: 'Ja, ich bin der Atheist und Gottlose, der dem Willen, der Nichts will, zuwider, lügen will, wie Desdemona sterbend log, lügen und betrügen will, wie der für Orest sich darstellende Pylades u. s. w.' (Jacobi an Fichte p. 32), of which it is, however, by no means an imitation or echo." By this turn of phrase, then, the Bishop himself lays weight on the indirect communication, and rejects those who would accuse the author of "untimely hunting after the piquant," when, after having expressed himself on the book's title, he expressly adds: "Thus this struggle in fear and trembling has not the least in common with the complacent coquetry with which the moral geniuses strive to get into such situations where they can show that they have not in vain read Schelling, that they too are in a position [7] 'einzig göttlich zu handeln.'"

Had Bishop Mynster now really been able to retain this first impression of his, that here in "Fear and Trembling" he met "a deep religious ground," "a mind that was equal to facing life's highest problems," had he in this respect had confidence in his own judgment, had himself faced these "highest problems," and so by his example become a guide for the many who so gladly leaned on his authority: what an entirely different turn would the course of the matter then have taken from the very beginning! When one grants an author his presuppositions, then it is surely self-evident that one must also grant him the necessary consequences of the presuppositions, that is to say, if the concession rests on insight and not on a fleeting mood. But in "Fear and Trembling" we have, after all, the presuppositions of principle. It belongs precisely to what is peculiar in Kierkegaard's nature that from the beginning he is so at one with himself, so inwardly finished. He was not a young man who grew old with the years, not a merry one who later became so earnest, not an aesthete who later became religious; no, he was originally all that he was, in a peculiar doubling, in his youth old, in his jest earnest, in his pain glad, in his severity mild, in his bitterness wistful: Kierkegaard is to such a degree an a priori nature that he almost lacks the perfectible.

In "Fear and Trembling" the principle is stated, completely stated; we see in this writing as in a mirror the author's whole intellectual physiognomy. If there is now in this physiognomy something essentially distorted, then it is truly striking that a man like Bishop Mynster could, through these distorted features, have thought he saw—"a deep religious ground." Or, if there is here in this disposition something false, and this falseness, as indeed it must, insofar as it lies in the presuppositions [8] and proceeds from the principles, is even a fundamental falseness; is it not then inexplicable that a connoisseur like Bishop Mynster, instead of at once catching sight

of this fundamental falseness, could let himself be dazzled, even to the degree that behind the pseudonymous character-mask he believed he discovered a spirit akin to his own, "a mind that was equal to facing life's highest problems"?

Restlessly and with overflowing productivity K. worked for a series of years at clarifying what he called his "existence-problems." His indirect communication, which behind its veil preserved inwardness, softened the polemical, and set a reconciling separation between actuality and ideality, procured quiet, so that the tactical advance could take place in all stillness.

It was Kierkegaard's plan to carry through a revision of the categories of existence, and to separate them from the muddle into which a misguided scientificity had dragged down "life's highest problems." He has solved this task with a certainty, thoroughness and many-sidedness that will in times to come warrant him a place among the thinkers of the first rank. But despite his respect for true scientificity where science applies, and although in practice he is a systematician second to none, it nevertheless belonged essentially to the sharpening of the problems of inwardness that he had set himself, continually, even systematically, to break the systematic form, everywhere to repel the stupidly scientific. He employed this tactic with great dexterity, added building to building, and enjoyed at last the satisfaction that the topping-out wreath was already waving on the last building of the complex when paragraph-earnestness came along, and naturally regarded the whole as a mass of "stray thoughts, aphorisms, fancies and flashes."

That Kierkegaard wanted to do away with "speculation," and that it was "the system" above all that suffered, was so conspicuous a fact that there were even those who thought that he passed off faith as a paradox merely to tease "the system." Of [9] this one can only say that everyone judges as he has understanding to, and besides recall the motto of the "Stages": "Solche Werke sind Spiegel, wenn ein Affe hinein guckt, kann kein Apostel heraus sehen."

How important it must have been to K., purely practically and for the sake of existence, to get "speculation" separated from "faith" will be understood when one looks at the intimate connection of the dogmatic-speculative school with what modern philosophy since Spinoza has called "immanence." In immanence not only is pagan ethics, in its noblest, Socratic form, grounded, but even within Judaism and Christianity there is, according to K.'s understanding, a popular, humane appropriation of the revealed religion that in a certain way likewise corresponds to immanence. So far is K. from wanting this religious-ethical intermediate stage overlooked, rejected or

disdained that on the contrary he has striven to develop its significance in a series of "upbuilding discourses."

For "a sure judgment" about K.'s authorship it is necessary that emphasis be laid here once more on this side of his productivity, which during the recent disputes has been all too much overlooked; for these discourses have just that mildness, soberness, quietness, that awakening and yet calming quality which one otherwise thinks is missing in K., and in which one is then accustomed to place the genuinely evangelical. What a difference it makes in this respect whether in one's judgment one is led by immediate feeling or by a clear thought, a determining category, can be seen from the following. Among the upbuilding discourses belongs precisely also the one on Job's words: "The Lord gave, the Lord took, blessed be the name of the Lord;" this discourse Bishop Mynster, as already mentioned, found so upbuilding that it must be able to "speak to, refresh every feeling heart," and would on that account call it a sermon. Here is a characteristic trait. The famous preacher appeals to "every feeling heart," and [10] wants the upbuilding discourse on Job called a "sermon," whereby he indicates that the view of life developed in the discourse is on a level with that in the ecclesiastical address; the dialectical author, whose endeavor it is to get the various categories of existence clarified, on the other hand does not want his discourse called a sermon, because he wants "sermon" to correspond to the Christian, and knows within himself that this discourse of his does not express what is in the proper sense Christian. His rejoinder through the pseudonym in "Unscientific Postscript" pp. 204 and 205 shows this. "Magister Kierkegaard has presumably known well enough what he was doing when he called the upbuilding discourses: upbuilding discourses, and why he refrained from the use of Christian-dogmatic determinations, from naming the name of Christ, etc., which one otherwise in our time does quite freely, while the categories, the thoughts, the dialectical in the presentation are only those of immanence. As the pseudonymous writings, besides what they directly are, indirectly are a polemic against speculation, so too are these discourses, not by not being speculative, but by not being sermons."

One will easily understand that there is no question here of "a Christian severity over against a given Christian mildness"; what is at issue here is to find "honesty" in the principles, to vindicate for the Gospel its distinctiveness, and to prevent its being categorially confused with a related but nevertheless subordinate standpoint of resignation and piety. Those who have followed the Kierkegaardian movement with some attention and reflection must surely know that this author did not let the matter

rest at having some pseudonyms muster a brilliant dialectic in order to exhibit "Stages on Life's Way," and with formal acumen maintain the claim that faith is a paradox; but that he was concerned to such a degree with the right understanding and religious- [11] practical carrying-through of the matter that, in a rich variety of popular discourses: *Upbuilding Discourses in Various Spirits*, *Works of Love*, *Christian Discourses*, *Discourses at the Communion on Fridays*, etc., he has shown with the utmost care, and illuminated in the most varied shadings, what the categories amount to, how, if possible, the people were to be worked upon, how one ought to speak in the congregation.

"The congregation! But is it then really not true, what is nevertheless asserted from so many sides, that S. Kierkegaard only wanted to be 'that single individual,' and became so infatuated with 'the single individual' that he entirely overlooked the congregation?" No, it is really untrue, categorically untrue. Only by a heightened emphasis on 'the single individual' did it become possible for him to secure the concept of the congregation against confusion with communities of a lower order; "insofar," he says, "as there is, religiously, a 'congregation,' this is a concept that lies on the other side of 'the single individual,' and that above all must not be confused with what may have validity politically: the public, the crowd, the numerical, etc."

"To me, the upbuilding author, it was and is therefore a joy that also . . . those grow more numerous who become attentive to what is said about 'the single individual'; it was and is a joy to me, for certainly I have faith in the rightness of my thought in spite of the whole world, but what, next to that, I would give up last is my faith in individual human beings. And this is my faith: that as much confusion and evil and abomination as there can be in human beings as soon as they become the irresponsible and unrepentant 'public,' 'crowd,' and the like, just as much truth and goodness and loveliness is there in them when one can get them as single individuals. Oh, and to what degree would human beings not become — human beings, and lovable, if they would become single individuals before God!" ("On My Work as an Author," p. 12). The exclusive interest with which K. worked for the religious showed itself, then, [12] also in this, that he not only wrote sermons but also, now and then, when occasion offered, actually preached, preferably at the Friday communion. Why he preferred Friday in particular he once explained in conversation in his joking way, lamenting that he did not have the voice to be a Sunday pastor and be heard by so many, yet thinking that with his weaker voice he might well be suited to be a Friday pastor.

For a closer determination of the point of view under which K. wished the Christian discourse, in the proper sense, to be understood, we shall here refer to the third part

of *Christian Discourses*, and bring out some points from its first discourse: "*Guard your foot when you go to the house of the Lord.*" The discourse begins thus:

"How still, how safe everything is in the house of God. For one who steps in there, it is as if with a single step he had come to a distant place, infinitely far away from all noise and shouting and loudness, from the terrors of existence, from the storms of life, from the scenes of dreadful events or the languishing expectation of them. And wherever you turn your gaze in there, everything will make you safe and calm. The lofty walls of the venerable building, they stand so firm, they guard so dependably the secure place of refuge, under whose mighty vault you are free of every pressure. And the beauty of the surroundings, their splendor, will make everything friendly to you, so inviting; it will, as it were, endear the holy place to you. . . ."

The reader understands that this attractive description is to be used precisely in order to repel with it. "How reassuring, how lulling, alas, and how much danger in this security!"

Yes, but the speaker is nevertheless no fanatic who knows only how to rail against something external, no iconoclast who reforms by smashing things to pieces; nor is he an unloving man who can have no sympathy with those who, from "noise and shouting," from "the terrors of existence," and from "the storms of life," seek a "place of refuge" behind the "lofty walls," an elevation of the soul under the "mighty vault." It is a religious thinker who in the discourse wishes to warn against the most dangerous, most beguiling of all illusions, namely that of devotion, when devotion is an aesthetic mood, a gentle illusion. "How reassuring, how lulling, alas, and how much danger in this security! And therefore it is indeed truly so, that it is really only God in the heavens who, in the actuality of life, can preach properly and to good effect to human beings, for he has the circumstances, has the destinies, has the strivings in his power. . . . But in the house of God, in the splendid house of God, when the pastor preaches — for reassurance!" "In earnest one wants to hear nothing of the terrible; one wants to play at it, roughly as when in peacetime the warriors, or rather the non-warriors, play at war; one wants, artistically, to demand everything of the speaker, but oneself one wants to sit, worldly and ungodly, quite secure in the house of God, because one knows well enough that no speaker has the power, the power that only Governance has, to seize a human being, to cast him into the grip of circumstances, to let dispensations and testings and spiritual trials preach to him in earnest for his awakening."

Given the notions that attempts have been made from several quarters to spread

among the people, outsiders would now expect that the aim of the discourse was, accordingly, to screw the severity of preaching up to such a pitch that people would thereby necessarily be frightened away from going to church. Anyone who has read the discourse knows how loose, how superficial and false this notion is. The discourse is indeed severe, but severe only insofar as the religious requirement is in itself severe; there is no exaggeration in the discourse; here, as everywhere in the religious, infinite severity is in turn essentially mildness. "When faith" — thus the discourse ends — "is [14] seen from its one side, the heavenly side, one sees in it only the reflected radiance of blessedness; but seen from its other side, the merely human side, one sees sheer fear and trembling. But then that discourse is surely also untrue which continually, and never otherwise than invitingly, alluringly, winningly, will speak of the visit to the house of the Lord, for seen from the other side it is terrifying. Therefore that discourse is also untrue which ended at last by altogether frightening people away from coming to the house of the Lord, for seen from the other side it is blessed, one day in God's house better than a thousand elsewhere". . . . "For to the speaker it is said: use all the ability granted you, willing to make every sacrifice and concession in self-denial, use it to win people — but woe to you if you win them in such a way that you leave out the terror; therefore use all the ability granted you, willing to make every sacrifice in self-denial, use it to terrify people — but woe to you if you do not, at bottom, after all use it to win them for the truth."

Since Christianity, according to Kierkegaard's conception, is not what one simply calls a doctrine, but in the essential sense "an existence-communication," it was of particular importance to him to make it as clear as possible how the speaker's own existence, without the severity of the requirement giving the human a pretext to evade the obligation and, into the bargain, blithely appeal to "faith" and to "the pure doctrine," could and should relate itself to the "existence-communication." In this respect even the different ways in which he had his writings published acquire a more than accidental significance. His work *"For Self-Examination"* he published, e.g., under his own name, whereas *"Practice in Christianity"* is, in its first edition, ascribed to a pseudonym. This is quite characteristic of what he calls his "tactics." To the language that "Anti-Climacus" uses in "Practice" there corresponds so strenuous [15] an existence that the author, for that very reason, has placed himself behind the pseudonym and announced himself only as editor: "In this work, dating from the year 1848, the requirement for being a Christian is forced up to a highest pitch of ideality. Yet the requirement surely ought to be said, presented, heard; Christianly,

there ought to be no haggling over the requirement, nor ought it to be suppressed — instead of making admission and confession concerning oneself.” The work, on the other hand, on which he has directly printed his name as author is meant, by the spirit and tone in which the presentation is held from first to last, to remind the reader of the relation of distance in which he himself stands to the ideals.

“Let me,” he says (For Self-Examination, p. 16), “determine precisely where, so to speak, I am. There is among us a right reverend old man, the highest clergyman of this Church; what he, what his preaching has willed, that same thing is what I will, only a tone stronger, which lies in the difference of my personality, and which the difference of the times demands”. . . . “Essentially I belong to the average, and it is here that I have worked for unrest in the direction of inwardization”.

“For Christianly there are two kinds of true unrest. The unrest in the heroes of faith and the witnesses to the truth, which aims at reforming an established order. So far out I have never ventured; that is not something for me, and insofar as anyone in our time might seem to want to venture so far out, I would not be disinclined to take up polemic against him, to help make it manifest whether he is the one who has the right”. . . .

“Instead of emptily and pompously passing myself off as a witness to the truth and inducing others foolhardily to want to be the same, I am a poet without authority, who moves others by means of the ideals.”

So much for the “authorship” in the first period. If the unbiased observer now succeeds, by these and similar features, in forming a tolerably “sure judgment” about S. Kierkegaard’s fundamental thoughts and endeavors in this first period of his public life, then a “sure judgment” about his “mental state” in the last period will follow as of itself. As the premises are, so too are the consequences, that is to say, when one has before one a man who wills, whatever it may cost, to be consistent. To grant the premises is therefore at once to acknowledge the consequences, that is to say, if the granting rests on insight, not on a fleeting mood. [16]

Now if it were always so entirely straightforward a matter that the agreement of the consequences with their premises must at once strike the eye of even a superficial observer, fuller explanations would here be superfluous. But anyone who knows something of life’s conflicts knows within himself that the case occurs not so very rarely in which what at bottom is pitiful inconsistency takes on the appearance of a consistent stance, while conversely, what by appearance looks like a break with all consistency is in its essence the only consistent thing. The more inwardness the

matter has, the more painfully will the collisions be felt; if what is at issue is the problems of inwardness themselves at their maximum, the knot will soon be drawn so tight that the famous passage in Jacobi may come true in earnest: "Ja, ich bin der Atheist und Gottlose, der, dem Willen, der Nichts will, zuwider, lügen will, wie Desdemona sterbend log. . . ."

As the connecting link between the first and the last period of our author's public life we have "Practice in Christianity." To the new printing of this work K. (Fædrel. 16 May 1855, no. 112) has sent a guiding word. "This book I have," he says, "let appear in an entirely unaltered printing, because I regard it as a historical document. . . . My earlier thought was: if the established order is to be defended, this is the only way. . . . In that way truth does after all come into the established order: it defends itself [17] by judging itself, it acknowledges the Christian requirement, it makes confession concerning itself about its distance. . . . This was in my thinking the only way out for defending the established order Christianly, and in order not to be guilty in any way whatever of proceeding too hastily, I ventured to give the matter that turn, in order to see what the old Bishop would do about it. If there was strength in him, he had to do one of two things: either declare himself decidedly for the book, venture to go along with it, let it be the defense that averts what the book poetically contains, the charge against the whole of official Christianity that it is an optical illusion 'not worth a pickled herring'; or else, as decidedly as possible, throw himself against it, brand it as a blasphemous and profane attempt, and declare official Christianity to be true Christianity. He did neither; he did nothing; he merely wounded himself on the book, and it became clear to me that he was powerless."

This is not the place to rebut all objections of every kind that have been raised against S. Kierkegaard of late. Though the accusations are many, the guilt is nevertheless only one: consistency! For consistency's sake we shall here confine ourselves to two prominent points: "the attack on Bishop Mynster," and the attack on the established order.

When Dr. Sören Kierkegaard, on Monday, 18 December 1854, with his article^{*)} in no. 295 of "Fædrelandet," began with the question: *Was Bishop Mynster a "witness to the truth," one of "the true witnesses to the truth" — is this the truth?* there were certainly many who took offense, many who cried inconsistency, many who thought of "Herostratic fame by hurling insults," etc., but, as it seemed, not very many who [18] stopped to consider that the sensational protest, in essentials, as far as the late Bishop

^{*)}The article was written in February 1854.

is concerned, contained nothing new, contained nothing other than what K. had already said beforehand, if in a milder tone, to Bishop Mynster himself, to his face, publicly and so plainly that the person concerned could not misunderstand it, and that without either the Bishop himself or any of his adherents at that time so much as making a show of having anything to object against it.

The public and definite protest against Bishop Mynster's being assigned a place among "the true witnesses to the truth" is to be read in the work *"For Self-Examination,"* pp. 16 and 17. For after K., on p. 16, with the words already quoted: "There is among us a right reverend old man, the highest clergyman of this Church; what he, what his preaching has willed, that same thing is what I will, only a tone stronger, which lies in the difference of my person", has, in expressions so telling that no one can mistake who "the right reverend old man, the highest clergyman of this Church" is, compared his activity with Bishop Mynster's, and thus directly placed himself at his side, indeed, with the addition: "a tone stronger, which lies in the difference of my personality", even — for in such matters it is a question neither of politeness nor of insult, but of truth — if one will, at his right hand; it is a matter of course that every word with which K. characterizes his distance from "the heroes of faith" and "the witnesses to the truth" necessarily also comes to apply to the Bishop. When, then, he says of himself that he "essentially belongs to the average," he says the same of Bishop Mynster; when he says of "the unrest in the heroes of faith and the witnesses to the truth, which aims at reforming an established order": "So far out I have never ventured, that is not something for me, and insofar as anyone in our time might seem to want to venture so far out, I would not be disinclined to take up polemic against [19] him". . . .; then anyone who has learned to read must involuntarily understand what is said as if it read: "So far out we, Bishop Mynster and I, have never ventured, that is not something for us; and insofar as anyone in our time might seem to venture so far out, we, Bishop Mynster and I, would not be disinclined to take up polemic against him." In short, every time Kierkegaard, with his "admissions" and "confessions," bows before "the heroes of faith" and bends before "the witnesses to the truth," it looks, in the reader's eyes, for all the world as if he were holding Bishop Mynster by the hand, in order thereby to induce this "highest clergyman" of the Church to do the same.

Now if either the Bishop himself or any of those closest to him had felt convinced that an encroachment had occurred here through this comparison, why was this not said to K. at once and straight out? One could, after all, for as K. later said (Supplementary Leaves to: This Must Be Said) "in such transactions one uses words

truthfully, like a descriptive naturalist; compliments have no place here," have told him without beating about the bush: "By comparing yourself in this way with 'the highest clergyman of this Church,' it is not Bishop Mynster you insult, but you violate the truth, in that by so unfitting a comparison you confuse the concepts. You want to clarify existences; what, pray, is your existence? You may well be the author with 'the rich cultivation,' 'the deep religious foundation,' 'the mind that is strong enough to look life's highest problems in the eye,' but your existence? Yes, there you are right, it 'belongs to the average.' But Bishop Mynster's existence, marked as it is with the signs of burdens, of crosses, of sufferings, does not belong to the average; or can you perhaps, in selfish blindness, not see that Bishop Mynster, besides what he is in the humane direction, is also something other and higher than the men we otherwise count among the foremost of the land, that he is precisely a witness to the truth, one [20] of the true witnesses to the truth, a link in the holy chain?"

Had one been so openhearted from the first, then K. would of course have known at once where he stood; now, on the other hand, since silence was observed, he surely never dreamed that it was perhaps only a diplomatic silence, but took, as one sees, the silence straightforwardly for a tacit admission. "Thus," he says in the protest, "when one lays the New Testament alongside, Bishop Mynster's proclamation of Christianity was, especially for a witness to the truth, a dubious proclamation of Christianity. But then there was, I thought, this true thing in him, that he, as I hold myself fully assured, was willing to confess before God and himself that he was by no means, by no means a witness to the truth—precisely this confession was in my thought the true thing."

Where, then, is the inconsistency? Had K. earlier begun by complimenting Bishop Mynster as a "witness to the truth" because at that time, for certain reasons, he liked Bishop Mynster so well, but afterwards raised a "Herostratic" protest against calling Bishop Mynster a witness to the truth because he now felt offended and could no longer like Bishop Mynster: that would have been inconsistent. Had he, moreover, to cover his inconsistency, juggled with the word: witness to the truth, saying that it could of course, e.g., mean both this and mean that, that he had admittedly earlier happened inadvertently to use the expression: witness to the truth, but had in no way meant that one should thereby think of: the true witness to the truth, whereas now, when he precisely wanted to point out what one should think of by the true witness to the truth, Bishop Mynster failed the test: then such conduct would not only have been inconsistent, it would have been contemptible. Now, on the other hand, since it is known before God and every man that Kierkegaard himself, in the last as well

as in the first period of his life, holds fast to the same, the very same concept of "the witness to the truth," and, with respect to being a witness to the truth, gives us in outline the same, the very same picture of Bishop Mynster: in what, then, does the inconsistency consist? What is it in this procedure of his that is supposed to be apt to arouse suspicion against his "mental state"? [21]

How Kierkegaard wanted the assurance given in his cited work (*For Self-Examination* p. 17) to be understood—that, insofar as anyone in the present age might seem to want to venture "so far out" (namely, like the "witnesses to the truth," to reform an established order), he was not disinclined "to take up polemic against him"—he has shown in his article (*Fædrel.* 31 Jan. 1851 No. 26) against Dr. Rudelbach. The article begins thus: "The remark is found" (in Dr. Rudelbach's work on civil marriage, 1851) "p. 70. In the text it says: Truly, the deepest and highest interest of the Church in our days is. . . . precisely to be emancipated from what can rightly be called habit- and state-Christianity. To this, then, note 121. This is the same thing that one of our most distinguished writers of recent days, Søren Kierkegaard, seeks to impress, to imprint, and, as Luther says, to drive into all those who will hear."

This article is, in accordance with Kierkegaard's principle, composed in a strictly conservative spirit. "Nothing," it says, "makes me so uneasy as everything that even merely smacks of this unhappy confusion of politics and Christianity, a confusion that can so easily bring a new kind of church reformation up and into fashion, the backward reformation which, reforming, puts a new worse in place of an old better, while it is nonetheless supposed to be certain and true that it is a reformation, on which occasion the whole town is illuminated. Christianity is inwardness, inwardization. If at a given time the forms under which one is to live are not the most perfect: well then, in God's name; if one can get them better: good. But essentially: Christianity is inwardness." "Should this belong to true Christianity, this faith in the saving power of politically attained free institutions, then I am no Christian, indeed, worse still, I am a very child of the devil; for, candidly speaking, I am even suspicious of these politically attained free institutions, especially of their saving and regenerating power. That is my Christianity, or so stupid a Christian am I, who moreover have never concerned myself with 'Church' and 'State' —that is much too big for me Nor have I ever fought for the emancipation of 'the Church,' any more than for that of the Greenland trade, of women, or any other emancipation whatsoever. As a single individual, with the aim 'the single individual,' aiming at inwardization in Christianity in 'the single individual,' I have consistently, with the weapons of the [22]

spirit, solely and only with the weapons of the spirit, fought to call attention to, and against letting oneself be deceived by, 'sense-deception' "It is not externally that Christianity is to be helped, by institutions and constitutions, and then least of all when these are not, in the old Christian way, to be won through suffering by martyrdoms, but, in the political way, socially-amicably gained by balloting or in the number lottery—to be helped in that way is on the contrary its ruin."

If, however, anyone thinks he finds in these utterances of a "conservative" disposition a proof that Kierkegaard had thereby so directly signed himself over to the established order that he could never, without expressly breaking with his own principles, permit himself to attack the established order, such a one will, by looking a little more closely, easily convince himself that he has been remarkably mistaken.

"Let me, however," it says, as in a postscript to the article, "add the following, so that what I say may not be misunderstood, as if it were my opinion that Christianity consisted solely and only in putting up with everything concerning the external forms" [23] "In the Acts of the Apostles we read the words: one ought to obey God rather than men. So there are cases where an established order can be of such a nature that the Christian ought not to put up with it, ought not to say that Christianity is precisely this indifference to the external."

"But let us now see how the Apostles did not conduct themselves—for how these venerable figures did conduct themselves, surely everyone knows." "The Apostles did not go about like that chatting with one another and saying: 'It is intolerable that the Sanhedrin imposes punishment on the proclamation of the Word; it is coercion of conscience. Yet what are we to do? Should we not try to get a few of us together, and then submit an address to the Sanhedrin, or try to get onto a synod; it would not be impossible that we then, by holding together with what are otherwise our enemies, could by balloting get the majority, and we could then get freedom of conscience to proclaim the Word.' God in heaven! Venerable figures, forgive me that I have had to speak thus; it was necessary."

"How, on the other hand, did they conduct themselves—for there are surely a good many who have forgotten it." "The Apostle is essentially a solitary man." "Let us suppose that someone meets him who says: Do you know that the Sanhedrin has made scourging the penalty for proclaiming the Word. The Apostle answers: Well, if the Sanhedrin has done so, then I shall accordingly be scourged. Tomorrow the Sanhedrin imposes the death penalty. The Apostle answers: Well, if the Sanhedrin has done that, then I shall accordingly be executed. He lets the established order

stand; not a word, not a syllable, not a letter in the direction of change in the external, not the most fleeting thought in his head, not a blink of the eye, not the movement of a feature in this direction. 'No,' says the Apostle, 'just let it stand unshaken, this established order, for this too stands unshaken, with God's help, that today I am scourged, tomorrow executed, or, what is the same thing, today I proclaim the Word, [24] and tomorrow, Amen.' "

"And here a Christian memento. Ordinarily, Christianity within Christendom is precisely indifference to the external in self-concern. But if someone so collides with the established order that it could occur to him that it is a question of conscience—great God, a question of conscience!—and he ventures to say this: then he has to be a solitary man, to fight in suffering, to choose martyrdom. Conscience and a matter of conscience can —this is eternally certain and lies in the matter itself, for conscience is no numerical determination—only be represented by a solitary man and in character, through action." . . .

When this article—precisely an article after Bishop Mynster's own heart—saw the light, there was hardly anyone among those who then held to the established order who found anything offensive in it, let alone anything so offensive that it could in the remotest way arouse suspicion against the author's "mental state." The principles stated in the article are indeed also really—as everyone who will use his understanding must admit—of such a nature that both the State and Christianity, that is to say, the Christianity of the New Testament, can, each according to its own interest, acknowledge them. What, in religious respects, causes the State its many vexations, clashes and disagreeable troubles is by no means "the solitary man who chooses to fight in suffering," but much rather the politicizing church system, the religious worldliness that nevertheless wants to rise above the worldly, that gregarious instinct of consciences which founds its freedom on "balloting." "Everything that is party and wants to act as party, perhaps even intriguingly —when it wants to appeal to 'conscience' against an established order, it incurs the guilt of an untruth," is a principle which, remarkably enough, can be embraced in equal measure, even if in opposite spirit, by statesmen and apostles.

If we now ask whether Kierkegaard's, as it seems, in the highest degree agitating, [25] violent and revolutionary public conduct in the last periods of his life can, without circumlocution, excusing turns of phrase or subtle artifices, be brought into agreement, into thorough, true and complete agreement, with the train of thought in the just-mentioned peaceable article, the answer is not far off. Only we must not, as regards

the last scenes, forget that the bow is drawn, not forget what a high-flown "testimony" it was that gave occasion for the bow's being drawn thus, not forget that the knot of inwardness has been pulled tight, that it is now earnest, really earnest with "the famous passage" in Jacobi: Ja, ich bin der Atheist und Gottlose!

Example: "*What is to be done—let it be done now through me or through another.*" (Whit Monday 1854.) S. Kierkegaard. *Fædrelandet*, 22 March 1855. No. 69.)

"First and foremost, on the largest possible scale, an end must be made of the whole official—well-meant—untruth which—well-meant—conjures up and maintains the illusion that it is Christianity that is proclaimed, the Christianity of the New Testament. In this respect the point is not to spare." . . .

"When that has been done, the matter is to be turned thus: is not the true state of affairs really this, that from generation to generation things have gone so far backward for us human beings, . . . that we, instead of the impudent drivel about Christianity being perfectible, about our going forward, indeed, about Christianity perhaps no longer even satisfying—that we, wretched, pitiful dozen- and score-men, in the end really cannot bear this divine thing which is the Christianity of the New Testament; [26] and that we must to that extent content ourselves with the kind of religiousness that is now the official one, after it has, be it noted, been made recognizable that it is by no means the Christianity of the New Testament. . . . Thus must the matter be turned; away, away, away with all blinding of the eyes, forth with the truth, out with it: we are not fit to be Christians in the New Testament's sense,—and yet we need to dare to hope for an eternal salvation." . . . "When the matter has then been turned thus, it will become evident whether there is anything true in this, whether it has Governance's consent,—if not, then everything must burst, so that in this horror individuals might again come to be who can bear the Christianity of the New Testament. But an end, an end must be made of the official—well-meant—untruth."

But is it not, after all, outrageous? "Ja, ich bin der Atheist und Gottlose, der dem Willen, der Nichts will, zuwider, lügen will." Had K., instead of engaging in such "radical" demands and "pessimistic" views, been able to bring himself to strike out on a smoother road; had he, tired of his position as "solitary man," at last followed the Christian gregarious instinct, or, to choose a better expression, been so "loving" as to be like others and act like others: things would have gone quite differently for him. Had he, instead of inveighing against "official Christianity" and causing scandal,

²⁶Here may be repeated what K. himself expressly stresses in an earlier article (Ved Biskop Mynsters Död): "Note *the year and the date.*"

shown the prudence to come forward, e.g., with a proposal for the ordering of the expected church constitution: he would surely at some point have succeeded "in getting onto a synod"; and once he had got onto the synod, and had been given the floor at the synod, perhaps even the most votes in the "balloting," then surely no cautious man would have ventured to say aloud of S. Kierkegaard that he was now acting inconsistently, or have permitted himself to raise any objection against his "mental state."

The smooth road was inviting enough; why, then, did he not choose the smooth road? [27]

To dazzle the thoughtless is a poor art; but anyone who will see must be able to see that K. could not, without breaking with his presuppositions, engage in reforms by the peaceful road. For him there was only a choice between one of two things: either to remain standing, as hitherto, on the proposition: "Ordinarily, Christianity within 'Christendom' is precisely indifference to the external in self-concern," or, when the course of things took this "ordinarily" away from him, then to attack the established order as resolutely, as unconditionally, as decisively as possible.

"As carefully as it has hitherto been concealed what my task might become, as cautiously as I have been preserved in the most impenetrable unrecognizability: just as decisively shall I also now, when the moment has come, make it recognizable. The question what Christianity is, and with it in turn the question of the State Church, whatever one wants to call it, the combination or the holding together of Church and State, shall be brought to the utmost decision. It cannot and shall not go on as it went on year after year." . . .

But is it not, then, open revolt? When K., in the work "For Self-Examination," p. 16, asks: "Am I then perhaps proclaiming tumult, the overturning of everything, disorder?" and then answers: "Truly, no"; could one not with regard to the "Moments" turn his words as a weapon against him, and say: "Truly, yes. Now you are proclaiming tumult, the overturning of everything, disorder!"? This matter is not complicated. The Kierkegaardian language is, without circumlocution, revolutionary. "For is it not true, you common man, that you can understand very well—I mean that precisely you can understand it far more easily and better than demoralized pastors and a corrupted gentility—is it not true, this you can understand excellently, that it is one thing to be persecuted, mistreated, scourged, crucified, beheaded and the like, another [28] thing, comfortably settled, with a family, steadily advancing, to live by depicting that another was scourged, etc." This language is revolutionary; no agitator will easily

outbid it.

Nevertheless, Kierkegaard's public conduct is the complete opposite of the revolutionary; we have incontrovertible proofs of this. "If someone so collides with the established order that it could occur to him that it is a question of conscience—great God, a question of conscience!—and he ventures to say this, then he has to be a solitary man, to fight in suffering, to choose martyrdom." These words Kierkegaard conscientiously strove, during his last public conduct, to put into character; we may well stress this fact without therefore needing to speak in high-flown terms and compliment the deceased as a martyr, or as a "witness to the truth." K. was and remained throughout the whole struggle a "solitary man": there was no one who helped him, no one who could, in a finite sense, come to his help. Even if there had been—which, however, there probably was not—someone or other among us who, with the same sureness about the categories, had also had the resoluteness and courage to venture equally far out, it would still not have come to a finite alliance between the two: each of the combatants, even if they had fought in the best understanding in the same spirit, for the same cause, would still have had to fight on his own, as a solitary man. But that such a procedure is the exact opposite of the revolutionary one, surely everyone sees. If one overlooks this contrast, how will one then explain to oneself that Kierkegaard's revolutionary language could be heard by "the common man" without anyone in the crowd stirring so much as a finger to attack the external? Or did Kierkegaard's words perhaps not know how to find the way to the passions? Does his language perhaps lack the inflaming quality that otherwise so easily produces a ferment? Or could "the common man," in his simplicity, nevertheless not quite understand him when he said [29] "that it is one thing to be persecuted, mistreated, scourged, crucified, beheaded, and the like, another thing, comfortably settled, with a family, steadily advancing, to live by depicting that another was scourged?" Or was it perhaps the apostolic authority of the pastors' church that impressed the common man?

For the fact that the Kierkegaardian protest, the strongest that in recent times has been made against an established church system, a protest which, while it sounded the whole country over with an echo in thousands upon thousands of souls, nevertheless first and last sounded in such a way that every man understood that what it was about was not an overturning in the external but a change in the internal, for this we have to thank not only the people's level-headedness and sound sense—sound sense could, alas, in such things easily be beguiled by an agitator—but essentially and categorically Kierkegaard's position as "solitary man."

What has otherwise been achieved here by the Kierkegaardian protest cannot be made clear in this context. The task was to point out in some features the consequences of his presuppositions, the inner agreement of his word and action from first to last. Those who lament that they cannot have "any sure judgment" about this man's "mental state in the last period of his life" ought seriously to consider whether the reason for this might not, after all, lie with themselves, namely that in their researches they have not yet come so far that they can have any sure judgment about "this man's" authorship in the first period.
